image of Ashoka appears to hark back to the political tradition of the *Arthashastra*.

The carnage did not end with the decapitated ministers. Many more came to be killed, and now the victims were women who formed part of Ashoka's harem.[3] Again, there was mass slaughter, revenge for having slighted the emperor. It all began in springtime as a consequence of a stroll by the emperor in a park on the eastern side of Pataliputra. While strolling there with his harem and enjoying trees fruiting or in bloom, the king came across a beautiful flowering Ashoka tree—'my namesake', as he put it. The sighting put him in a good mood and he is said to have become 'very affectionate' towards his concubines, no doubt a euphemism for the pleasures of the royal bed. Here it seems that the young women of his harem did not sufficiently enjoy caressing his body, which was rough-skinned. And so, after he fell asleep, 'they, out of spite, chopped all the flowers and branches off the Ashoka tree.' On learning of this the king is said to have burned alive five hundred of these women as revenge for their dismembering his beautiful Ashoka tree. (The number 500 seems a favourite in this text, as 100 and 101 are in others.)

At this point, alarmed by the scale of the killings that Ashoka was personally carrying out, his prime minister is said to have made him appoint a royal executioner who could be delegated the task of future mass extermination, leaving the king unsullied. A suitable candidate was found in a Magadhan village, a weaver boy called Girika who, on account of his ferocity and sadistic tendencies, had the suffix 'fierce' attached to his name. 'Girika the Fierce'—or Chandagirika—is said to have crowed about his prowess to the king's men when they asked him if he felt up to the task of being Ashoka's executioner: the boy exclaimed that he 'could execute the whole of Jambudvipa.' This seems to have got him the job, for we next hear that at his request the king built a jail in Pataliputra, one that people called 'the beautiful gaol' because 'it was lovely from the outside' while 'inside it